# Matthew 23:25 — Summary

**Date**: 2026-06-29

**Baseline Translation**: ESV (English Standard Version)

**Original Language**: Greek (NA28/Nestle 1904)

**Analyst**: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

**Passage Context**: Seven Woes pericope, the cup and platter image (v25) — Jesus returns to the scribes/Pharisees/hypocrites of v1, now indicting them for cleansing the outside of their vessels while the inside remains full from robbery and incontinence. The spatial metaphor — surface purity concealing internal corruption — captures the essence of hypocrisy itself.

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## Diff Analysis: What Got Lost?

### What the Standard Translation Loses

| # | Standard (ESV) | What's Lost | Why It Matters |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | "cleanse" | The Greek (kaθarɪze) is categorized as `ritual>purity_rite` — a purification verb used for cleansing from leprosy, cleansing the conscience, purifying from stains. The LSJ cites this verse directly. | ESV's "cleanse" sounds like simple washing. The Greek carries the force of a PURIFICATION RITE — the same word used for moral and spiritual cleansing. The Pharisees perform the ritual of purification |

| # | Standard (ESV) | What's Lost | Why It Matters |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | on the OUTSIDE only. |
| 2 | "the outside" | The Greek (ἔξωθεn) means "external, from without" — and the LSJ explicitly contrasts it with ἔswωθεn (from within) as a known classical pair. | The spatial opposition IS the theology: outside vs. inside, surface vs. interior. Jesus is using a recognized classical paired construction, not inventing a contrast. |
| 3 | "cup" | The Greek (ροτήριον) means a drinking-vessel — but by extension "the contents thereof, i.e. a cupful (draught); figuratively, a lot or fate." Three semantic levels. | ESV captures only the literal vessel. The figurative sense — a cup as one's LOT or FATE — transforms the verse: the Pharisees cleanse the exterior of their lot while the interior of their lot is full of robbery. The cup is a metaphor for life itself. |
| 4 | "platter" | The Greek (ραροψίδος) means a side-dish — but the LSJ shows it used metaphorically for "fresh tastes of misery." The LSJ cites Ev.Matt. 23.25 for this sense. | The platter isn't neutral. It's a source of BITTER PORTIONS — "fresh tastes of misery." The Pharisees cleanse the outside of the very |

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|---|---|---|---|
| | | | thing that dispenses bitterness. |
| 5 | "full" | The Greek (γέmw) means "to swell out, be full" — and the LSJ cites THIS VERSE for the construction γέmw ἐξ ("be full from/out of"). The preposition ἐξ denotes ORIGIN. | Not "full of" (contents) but "full FROM" (origin). Extortion and excess are the SOURCE of the fullness, not just what fills the cup. Robbery is where the fullness COMES FROM. |
| 6 | "from" | The Greek (>ξ) is "a primary preposition denoting origin — the point whence action or motion proceeds." It indicates SOURCE, not merely contents. | The inside doesn't just contain extortion; extortion is its FOUNDATION, its starting point. The distinction matters: they aren't full of robbery as contents — they are full FROM robbery as origin. |
| 7 | "extortion" | The Greek (άρpagῆ) means "pillage, seizure, robbery, rape" — taking by force. Categories: `action>destroy_violence` and `morality_spirituality>sin_evil`. | Modern "extortion" suggests overcharging. The Greek means ROBBERY — violent taking, rifling, seizure. The cup's inside is full from VIOLENT |

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|---|---|---|---|
| | | | SEIZURE. The word carries the force of destruction, not just greed. |
| 8 | "excess" | The Greek (ἀ·kρasia) means "want of self-restraint" — not abundance but INCONTINENCE. Categories: `emotion_mind>attitude_character` and `morality_spirituality>sin_evil`. | "Excess" in modern English means "too much." The Greek means a LACK OF SELF-CONTROL. The cup's inside is full from the inability to restrain oneself — not abundance but incontinence, a failure of self-governance. |
| 9 | The outside/ inside contrast | The Greek uses ἔξωθen (outside) and ἔswωθen (within) — a paired opposition the LSJ marks as a known classical construction. The δὲ between them is adversative ("but"). | The spatial metaphor IS the theological critique: the Pharisees perform purification on the exterior while the interior is full from sin. The gap between surface and substance IS the hypocrisy. |
| 10 | Paired sins: pillage + incontinence | "Extortion" (pillage — taking by force, a sin of COMMISSION) and "excess" (incontinence — failing to restrain oneself, a sin of OMISSION) form a complete moral failure. | Together they cover both forms of moral transgression: active violence (taking what isn't yours) and passive indulgence (failing to control |

| # | Standard (ESV) | What's Lost | Why It Matters |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | yourself). The cup's inside is full from BOTH — robbery AND incontinence. |

## Concepts Flattened

- **Purification rite reduced to washing**: "Cleanse" is a purification verb with moral and spiritual connotations — the same word used for cleansing from leprosy and purifying the conscience. The Pharisees perform a PURIFICATION RITE on the outside only.
- **Cup as lot/fate reduced to literal vessel**: "Cup" has three semantic levels — literal vessel → cupful/draught → lot/fate. The figurative sense transforms the verse: the Pharisees cleanse the exterior of their LOT while the interior is full of robbery.
- **Platter as source of misery reduced to literal dish**: "Platter" has a metaphorical sense — "fresh tastes of misery." The platter dispenses bitterness, and the Pharisees cleanse its outside.
- **"Full from" reduced to "full from"**: The Greek construction γέμω ἐξ (be full from/ out of) uses the preposition of ORIGIN — extortion is the SOURCE of the fullness, not merely its contents. The distinction is between "full of" (contents) and "full from" (origin).
- **Extortion as robbery reduced to overcharging**: The Greek means pillage, seizure, robbery — violent taking. Modern "extortion" suggests overcharging, a milder sin. The cup's inside is full from ROBBERY.
- **Excess as incontinence reduced to "too much"**: The Greek means want of self-restraint — an inability to govern oneself. Modern "excess" suggests abundance. The cup's inside is full from INCONTINENCE, a failure of self-control.

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## Expanded Translation (4K)

*The recovered "director's cut" — original language nuances restored in readable English. Parenthetical notes explain the nuance recovered.*

**25** Woe unto you (an exclamation of pain and anger — not just "alas" but the cry of grief itself), scribes (and "scribes" means secretaries, registrars, subordinate officials — a word sometimes used as a term of contempt) and Pharisees (and "Pharisees" means separatists — those who have made themselves exclusively religious, a sect apart), hypocrites (and "hypocrites" literally means stage-players — actors under an assumed character, performing a role rather than living a truth)! For ye cleanse (and "cleanse" is a purification verb — the same word used for cleansing from leprosy, cleansing the conscience, purifying from stains; its semantic category is "purity rite," not just "wash") the outside (and "the outside" means externally — from without, the exterior surface, opposed to the inside) of the cup (and "cup" means a drinking-vessel, but by extension a cupful or draught, and figuratively a LOT or FATE — the cup is a metaphor for one's portion in life) and of the platter (and "platter" means a side-dish, the receptacle — but the classical lexicon shows it used metaphorically for "fresh tastes of misery," a source of bitter portions), but within (and "within" is the precise opposite of "the outside" — from inside, the interior) they (the cup and platter) are full (and "full" means to swell out, to be full — and the classical lexicon cites THIS VERSE for the construction "full from," meaning full BY ORIGIN OF) from (and "from" is the preposition of ORIGIN — denoting the point whence something proceeds; extortion and excess are the SOURCE of the fullness, not merely its contents) extortion (and "extortion" means pillage — seizure, robbery, rape, taking by force; not overcharging but violent taking, rifling) and excess (and "excess" means want of self-restraint — not "too much" but an inability to control oneself, an incontinence, a lack of self-governance)!

## Baseline Translation (ESV)

> *25 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye cleanse the outside of the cup and of the platter, but within they are full from extortion and excess.*

## Individual Verse Analyses

Each verse has its own detailed analysis file with full Greek text, word-by-word analysis, grammatical observations, cultural context, and cross-references:

- Matthew 23:25 — The cup and platter image: the Pharisees cleanse (perform a purification rite on) the outside (the external surface, from without) of the cup (a drinking-vessel, figuratively one's lot or fate) and platter (a side-dish, metaphorically a source of bitter portions), but within (from inside) they are full from (full BY ORIGIN OF — the preposition denotes source, not contents) extortion (pillage, robbery, violent seizure — a sin of commission) and excess (incontinence, want of self-restraint — a sin of omission)

## Theological Insights Recovered

1. **The cup as metaphor for life itself**: The Greek potȟrion (cup) has a figurative sense: "a lot or fate." The cup isn't just a vessel — it's a metaphor for one's portion in life. When Jesus says the Pharisees cleanse the outside of the cup while the inside is full from robbery, he's saying: you make your outward lot appear clean while your inward reality is full of violence. The cup is your LIFE — and you're only cleaning its surface.

2. **"Cleanse" as purification rite**: The semantic category of kaθarıze is `ritual>purity_rite` — this is a PURIFICATION verb, not just a washing verb.

The LSJ shows it used for cleansing from leprosy, cleansing the conscience of dead things, purifying from stains. Jesus charges the Pharisees with performing the RITUAL of purification — but only on the outside. They go through the motions of purity without the substance. The ritual without the substance IS the hypocrisy.

3. **The outside/inside opposition as theological image**: The Greek uses ἔξωθεν (outside) and ἔσωθεν (within) — a paired opposition the LSJ explicitly marks as a known classical construction. The spatial metaphor IS the theology: the Pharisees cleanse the exterior while the interior is full from sin. The gap between surface and substance IS the hypocrisy — and it connects directly to v3's "hypocrites" (stage-players, actors performing a character). The actor performs the outside; the inside is full from robbery.

4. **"Full from" as origin, not contents**: The LSJ cites this verse for the construction γέμω ἐξ ("be full from/out of"). The preposition ἐξ denotes ORIGIN — the point whence something proceeds. Not "full of" (extortion as contents) but "full FROM" (extortion as origin/source). The inside doesn't just contain robbery; robbery is its FOUNDATION, its starting point. Extortion is where the fullness comes from.

5. **Extortion as robbery and violence**: The Greek ἁρπαγῆ means pillage, seizure, robbery, rape — taking by force. The LSJ shows it means BOOTY and PREY as well as the ACT of seizing. This isn't "extortion" as overcharging — it's ROBBERY, violent taking, rifling. The cup's inside is full from VIOLENT SEIZURE. The word carries the force of destruction and violation.

6. **Excess as incontinence and failure of self-governance**: The Greek ἀκρασια means "want of self-restraint" — not abundance but INCONTINENCE. The primary category is `emotion_mind>attitude_character` — this is about CHARACTER, not quantity. The cup's inside is full from the inability to restrain oneself — a failure of self-governance, not an excess of abundance. The Pharisees cannot GOVERN themselves. They lack the very self-control that Jesus has been modeling throughout the chapter.

7. **Paired sins: commission and omission**: "Extortion" (pillage — taking by force, a sin of COMMISSION) and "excess" (incontinence — failing to restrain oneself, a sin of

OMISSION) form a complete moral failure. Together they cover both forms of moral transgression: active violence (doing what you shouldn't) and passive indulgence (failing to do what you should). The cup's inside is full from BOTH — robbery AND incontinence. The pairing is deliberate: the Pharisees fail in both directions simultaneously.

8. **The return of scribes/Pharisees/hypocrites**: Same three words from v1, repeated in v23, now in v25. Jesus returns to the same targets with each woe. But each woe adds a new indictment: v1 = general condemnation, v23 = you tithe trifles and omit justice, v25 = you cleanse the outside while the inside is full of robbery and incontinence. The pattern is cumulative: each woe sharpens the critique. The cup and platter image adds the SPATIAL dimension — the hypocrisy isn't just about what they do (tithe trifles, omit justice) but about WHERE they do it (outside vs. inside, surface vs. substance).

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## Notes for Further Study

1. **Eucharistic context of the cup**: The LSJ notes pothrion (cup) is used in the Eucharist context ("the Cup in the Eucharist"). Jesus repurposes Eucharistic vessels as metaphors for moral state. Worth exploring whether other Matthew 23 verses use Eucharistic imagery.

2. **The platter's metaphorical bitterness**: The LSJ shows paροψis (platter) used metaphorically for "fresh tastes of misery." The platter dispenses bitterness. Is Jesus saying the Pharisees cleanse the outside of the very thing that gives them bitter portions? The image deserves further exploration.

3. **Connection to Matthew 8:2 (leprosy)**: The LSJ shows kaθarιze used in Ev.Matt.8.2 for cleansing from leprosy. Jesus uses the same purification verb in v25 — but there the cleansing is from a disease, here it's only of the exterior surface. The contrast makes the Pharisees' cleansing look like a cure that only treats the skin. Worth a full cross-reference analysis.

4. **The "full from" construction in classical Greek**: The LSJ cites this verse for γέμω ἐξ. Worth searching for other uses of this construction in the NT to see if Jesus uses it elsewhere with different objects. The construction may carry a stronger sense of ORIGIN than modern "full from" captures.

5. **Manuscript variants**: The verse numbering for the Seven Woes pericope has known discrepancies between Greek and ESV/KJV editions (see v13-14 swap). Worth verifying that v25 is consistent across editions.

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**Analysis completed by**: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)
**Review status**: Draft - Ready for Review